cycles, scores of cars and rented yellow school buses have edged past paddy fields to the vast parking grounds outside. The usual chips-and-coke, lime soda and burger stalls and poorer vendors selling papad crowd a makeshift entrance. Inside the compound, four large shamianas, all equipped with state-of-the-art video screens and speakers, line the walkway leading up to the mammoth church building—it's still under construction, and the spires rise above an edifice of unpainted brick. Upon completion, they claim it will be Asia's largest church. But it's already functional. Buzzing, rather. Narula is beaming live from Birmingham, where he had gone to inaugurate the second branch of his Church of Signs and Wonders in the UK. A posse of uniformed security and white-clad attendants—women in salwar kameez, men in shirt-pants—hover around everywhere officiously, keeping an eye on the constant stream of footfalls. Among them, past massive generators and stalls selling the Bible in three languages, Narula's *My Book of Prophesies* and the ministry's magazine, a man guides his wheelchair-bound mother to the portals of deliverance.

A disparate bunch, they include the big pastors with huge flocks, multiple branches, millions of YouTube followers, and rural pastors who preach from home

THE RUSTIC REFORMERS

That same Sunday morning, 100 km away on the road to Ajnala, no ripples disturb the air of slow ease that pervades rural Punjab. A culvert, a ribbon of dust around a hamlet and buffaloes ambling into a pond, then the asphalt cuts straight into the countryside, tracing miles along a canal, past freshly cut paddy and clumps of poplar trees out of which they make match-sticks. The village of Sehnsra Kalan swims into view with all the confidence of an urban middle-class neighbourhood: a sparkling white gurdwara and prosperous houses lining its brick roads, adorned with wood-and-glass balconies. Deeper into its catacomb, though, the lanes narrow down to the rural average, and a form-shifting spectacle offers itself, like in a village magic show.

A tall, swarthy man appears to lead the way on a bike—he wears a neat white shirt tucked into grey trousers, a trimmed salt-and-pepper beard and a solicitous smile. By physique, you'd guess he was a policeman; by attire, a pastor out of his cassock but still on Sunday duty. In fact, Gurnam Singh is both: opposites merge in the same person, along lines dictated by a personal story (see *"I don't convert...*). The track leads to a peepul-shaded chaupal in front of another gurdwara, a humble



affair this time—a couple of loudspeakers on a flat roof, a tiny grocer's shop set into its worn-out front wall. Down a lane by its side, hugging its right periphery wall, a small white house with a fibreglass gate and a Hyundai Aeon in front announces its quiet presence. From the chaupal, the cross that adorns its false gabled roof is nearly inconspicuous. Then the hallelujahs ring out. Intermittently. Rising and falling through the loudspeaker static, they meld into the village soundscape outside—the chirping mynahs and parrots, a Sardar selling onions and potatoes on a Bullet, calling out to customers in the age-old singsong way, a phut-phut